

# The Lost Lantern Festival

The Floating Isles are islands adrift in a calm sky, in a realm where magic only ever helps: it grows, it heals, it changes one thing into another, and it lets you speak with animals and objects. It never harms. On the home island, the House of the Little Mages sits at the highest point, where young mages learn their first spells, and the city where the families live spreads below. Inside the school grounds lies the Great Garden, the green heart of the whole island. Here nobody loses; you find your way by being clever and kind.



# The Lost Lantern Festival

*Read aloud, or let an older child read. Pause at the questions and let everyone share their ideas. There are no wrong answers, only new ones to try.*

## Before you begin

Tonight should be the best night of the year: the Festival of Lights, when every family on the Floating Isles sends a glowing sky lantern drifting up into the calm evening sky until the whole heavens shine. But from the high windows of the House of the Little Mages, you can see that something is wrong. The sky is empty and dark. Down below, Lantern Square sits grey and silent, and not a single light is rising.

You are young mages, and tonight the lights are yours to find. You shoulder your bags, share a quick and certain look, and set off down the winding path. "Let us bring the festival back," you say, and the dark square waits for you below.

*What is your mage name? Which magic feels most like you tonight: Light, Grow, Change, or Voice?*

## Stop 1: The Dim Square

Lantern Square should be ringing with music and warm with a hundred small flames. Instead it is hushed and shadowed, and only one sky lantern remains, sitting forgotten on a cold stone with its little flame snuffed out.

The Mist Cat pads out of the evening fog, soft and grey, and settles beside the lantern. It looks from the cold wick to the sky above, where the faintest ribbon of light still hangs in the air, drifting up and away toward a distant bank of cloud.

*How will you wake the lantern's flame, and how might you discover where all the others have gone? Try something, and see what the night gives back.*

When the little flame catches and glows, the lantern lifts from the stone and rises gently along that ribbon of light, as if inviting you to follow. So you do, up and up toward the waiting clouds.

## Stop 2: The Cloud Bank

At the very edge of the island, where the ground gives way to open sky, you come to a low bank of clouds, soft as wool and faintly warm. Look closely and you will see it: here and there a cloud glows quietly from within, as though it has swallowed a little sun. The missing lanterns are tucked away inside.

A Messenger Butterfly, bright as a coal, comes spiralling down to lend a wing.

*Which clouds are keeping a lantern, and how can you be sure? And once you know, how will you reach so high and gather them in? Try something, and see.*

One by one you coax the glowing lanterns out of their cloudy nests, until they bob and circle around you in a soft, happy swarm of light. Only the grandest lantern of all, the great one that crowns the whole festival, is still nowhere to be seen.

## Stop 3: The High Ledge

You tip your heads back and find it at last. Far above the square, the biggest festival lantern has drifted up against a jutting rocky ledge and snagged there, glowing stubbornly out of reach. It is much too high to climb to, and in any case you would never want anyone to risk a fall. This one must come down softly and safely.

The evening breeze loops and curls around the ledge, patient and willing.

*How will you bring the great lantern down without anyone in danger? Could you grow something soft to catch it, or ask the breeze for the gentlest of nudges, or change a pebble into a kindly hook? Try something, and see.*

When the great lantern drifts down at last and settles into your waiting hands, the whole square seems to hold its breath. Every lantern is found now, but one question still glimmers unanswered: why did the lights leave at all?

## **Nimbo the Cloud-Whale Calf**

High in the quiet clouds you find the answer curled up small: a young cloud-whale calf, shy and round, made of pale drifting cloud, with a soft warm glow shining deep inside it. Its name is Nimbo. It was Nimbo, you understand now, who gathered every lantern, one by one, into the sky.

Not out of mischief, and not to spoil a thing. Nimbo had been alone for a long time in the wide empty evening, and when the warm little lights began to rise, it loved them so dearly that it could not bear to let them drift on by.

There is no battle here, and there never was a villain.

*What do you say to Nimbo? How can you show it that it has not been forgotten, and that there is a place for it down at the festival too?*

When you offer Nimbo your friendship, it lets out a happy, rumbling sigh and opens its cloudy heart, and all the gathered light streams free. The sky lanterns rise as one, the evening blooms into warm and endless gold, and Nimbo, brightest of them all, drifts gently down to take its place among the families. The Festival of Lights has begun, and no one is alone in it.

You did this together. You were clever, and you were kind, and on the Isles that is the only way anyone ever wins.

## The Story in Pictures



A dim festival square with one unlit lantern, the Mist Cat beside it, and a faint trail of light leading up to the clouds.



A low cloud bank where a few clouds glow warmly from hidden lanterns, a Messenger Butterfly nearby and a vine growing up to reach them.



The biggest lantern resting against a high rocky ledge, a soft breeze around it and a vine with a cushion of leaves grown up below.



A shy cloud-whale calf glowing with gathered light as two little mages offer friendship and the freed lanterns rise into a golden sky.

# My Adventure Sheet

Draw your hero

My name

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I am a hero of

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My energy stars (colour one in when you spend it)



My magics



My magic is

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It can

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My magic is

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It can

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My magic is

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It can

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What I carry

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*Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.*

# Wits and Wonder

## Story Pack

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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